

Three-bean, three-chile chili with seitan and sun-dried tomatoes

I take my chili seriously, which is why I am often disappointed with the industrial sludge that passes for the real thing in many restaurants. Such chilis are either too soupy or lack any kind of vigor or character. A lot of interesting things are going on in this chili. The fusion of different dried chiles plus the sun-dried tomatoes and an interesting variety of spices and beans. Because the flavors will triumphantly build as the hours go by, I highly recommend that you make this in advance.

½ cup dried adzuki beans [90g]

½ cup dried black beans [90g]

½ cup dried white cannellini beans [90g]

3 ounces sun-dried tomatoes [90g]

3 dried pasilla chiles

2 dried mulato or ancho chiles

1 dried chipotle chile

6 garlic cloves, unpeeled

2 tablespoons olive oil

2 medium onions, coarsely chopped

1 celery rib, chopped

1 large red bell pepper, cut into thin strips

1 large yellow bell pepper, cut into thin strips

1 tablespoon cumin seeds, lightly crushed

1 tablespoon dried basil

1 tablespoon dried Mexican oregano

1 teaspoon salt

2 cinnamon sticks

1 cup apple juice [250ml]

1 cup dark beer or vegetable stock [250ml]

3 tablespoons balsamic vinegar

1 tablespoon soy sauce

1 tablespoon molasses

1 pound [500g] packaged seitan, cut into ½-inch [1-cm] chunks

1 bunch of scallions, thinly sliced

1 cup Mexican queso a ñejo or feta cheese, or more to taste [125g]

1. **Rinse** all the beans and pick them over to remove any grit. Place them in a large pot and add enough cold water to cover by 2 inches [5cm]. Let stand for 6 to 8 hours or overnight. Drain, return the beans to the pan, and cover them with fresh water. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat to a simmer, and cook until the beans are tender but not falling apart, 45 to 60 minutes. Drain, reserving 1 cup [250ml] of the bean liquid, rinse briefly, and drain well. Return the beans to the cooking pot.
2. While the beans are cooking, soak the tomatoes in hot water to cover until they are soft, about 15 minutes. **Drain** and coarsely chop the tomatoes.
3. In a dry cast-iron skillet, **toast** the chiles over medium heat, 2 or 3 at a time, by laying them flat on the pan and pressing down with a spatula for 15 to 30 seconds, until they crackle and give off a slight wisp of smoke. Be careful not to burn them. Flip over and repeat on the other side. Transfer to a medium bowl. When all the chiles are toasted, cover them with very hot water and let soak until very soft, about 30 minutes.
4. In the same cast-iron skillet, toast the unpeeled garlic, stirring occasionally, until lightly browned, 7 to 10 minutes. Set aside and let cool, then peel. **Place** in a blender or food processor. Add the softened chiles and ½ cup [125ml] of the reserved soaking liquid. Puree until smooth. Add a little more liquid if the mixture is too thick.
5. In the same skillet, **heat** the olive oil over medium-high heat. Add the onions and cook, stirring often, until very soft and lightly browned, 7 to 9 minutes. Add the celery and the bell peppers and cook until tender, about 3 minutes. Add the cumin, basil, oregano, salt, and cinnamon sticks and cook, stirring, for about 1 minute, until the spices are fragrant and begin sticking to the bottom of the pan. Add the chile-garlic puree and cook, stirring constantly, for 1 to 2 minutes.
7. Immediately pour in the apple juice and beer or broth. **Stir** in the vinegar, soy sauce, and molasses. Add the cooked beans, sun-dried tomatoes, seitan, and half the scallions. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat to a simmer, and cook, partially covered, until the chili is thick and rich-tasting, 45 to 60 minutes. Add more reserved bean liquid if you think the chili needs more moisture. Season with additional salt and pepper to taste. Serve in bowls with the cheese and remaining scallions sprinkled on top.

SERVE 6 TO 8

note This recipe calls for seitan, either homemade or store-bought. If making homemade, you will need to prepare it ahead of time. However, because there are already several steps in making this recipe, I think using store-bought seitan is perfectly acceptable.

